

LET ME TRY · FREE PRINTABLE

From 'Say Sorry' to Real Repair

A 4-step script for hurtful moments · Ages 2–4

Apologies matter. But young children learn empathy by noticing feelings and helping, not by being made to say a word. Here's a calm sequence you can use every time.

What the research suggests

- Young children connect apologies with feelings: they expect a child who apologises to feel bad, and see a victim as feeling better after an apology (Smith, Chen & Harris, 2010).
- A rushed, coerced 'sorry' skips the part where the child notices the other person's feelings.

The 4 steps

- 1. Stop and keep everyone safe: “I won't let you hit.”
- 2. Calm first: hold, breathe, wait. Teaching comes after.
- 3. Notice: “Look at her face. She's crying. Her arm hurts.”
- 4. Repair: “What can we do to help?” Get a cold cloth, give a hug, return the toy.

Model apologies yourself

- “I'm sorry I shouted. I was frustrated. I'll try to use a calm voice.”
- “Sorry I forgot your water bottle. Let's go back and get it.”

If they won't do anything

That's okay. Repair on their behalf while they watch: “I'll get a cloth for Riya. Maybe next time you can help.” Modelling is still teaching.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Smith, C. E., Chen, D., & Harris, P. L. (2010). When the happy victimizer says sorry: Children's understanding of apology and emotion. British Journal of Developmental Psychology, 28(4), 727–746.